



PRESIDENT PRATIBHA PATIL BURIES A TIME CAPSULE AT IIT-K'S GOLDEN JUBILEE

terminated students, describing some of the teachers as "terrorists". Pal shot off a letter to the president and the chairman of the senate—the institute's regulatory body responsible for maintaining standards of education—that sought a change in regulations, if not attitudes. "It's well-known that any student who asks too many questions or fails to answer any question is targeted and in a subtle way projected as sub-standard," says Pal.

Kilkil Sachan, a terminated B.Tech student, says, "Students work hard to compete and join IIT-K for a bright future, not to be driven out. But in the name of autonomy, IIT-K is playing with the future of students and getting away with it." The system, the toughest and most ruthless among all the IITs, the number of which has grown from the original four—Kharagpur, Mumbai, Chennai and Delhi—to 15 now, is killing dreams at a time when the Ministry of Human Resource Development (HRD) is thinking of relaxing the examination system so that a more conducive learning atmosphere can be created for students. "It appears that IIT-K has yet to

come out of the paradigm in which academic performance is used to penalise students," says Pandey. The HRD Ministry refuses to intervene on the ground that the IITs are autonomous institutions.

Not surprisingly, IIT-K Registrar Sanjeev S. Kashalkar doesn't agree. "Only those who have not been able to meet academic requirements are barred from appearing at the examinations," he says. Each semester is a self-contained session and under the system those who fail have to re-register after a review. This time there were 117 students who failed and were shortlisted but 43 didn't make the cut after a review and the rest were re-registered, according to Kashalkar. The review process is comprehensive and inputs from its various components come to the 168-member senate for discussion, he says. Not so, says Pal, claiming that hardly one-fourth of the senate members attend key meetings. "Instead of the students, the teachers must be punished as it is their duty to ensure that students meet standards," he says.

Students call the review a golden

trap, as they go on for months and one has to appeal and reappeal till it's time to move out. Soon after this year's round of terminations, a group of sc/st students sent a lengthy petition to the HRD Ministry, calling themselves the "targets of caste discrimination and victimisation". The petition said: "We come here with lots of expectations and hopes, but as we step in here, our hopes are shattered as we face caste-based discrimination in terms of academics and other activities. We are being discouraged from continuing our studies and are failed intentionally in various subjects to ruin our careers."

Their lives are in the balance too. The petition also alleges that the number of suicides at IIT-K has gone up in the last few years. It's not as if there are no suicides at other IITs. Roorkee and Mumbai have reported suicides due to "pressure" and there is a suicide or attempt at Kharagpur roughly every two years. But IIT-K is in a league of its own; at least two students commit or try to commit suicide every semester, say sources. IIT-K has psychiatrists who occasionally provide counselling. The institute has introduced a special one-year coaching programme for entry level sc/st students to bring them at par with students from more advantaged sections. But it doesn't seem to have helped.

"The administration says that one can re-appeal any number of times. With this hope, we wait six months for the next senate meeting but again we come to know that our re-appeal has been rejected without being provided concrete reasons." An expelled student says that a sc student from the 2003 batch has been re-appealing for the last 18 months but in vain. One faculty head agreed that the situation is "really terrible".

IIT-K's motto says: Lead me from darkness to light. Perhaps it's time to reconnect with those noble words. ■

“ The reason behind so many terminations at IIT-K should be investigated. ”

VIJAY NARAYAN PAL, IIT-K Alumnus and Professor

